

A BRIEF HISTORY

From the humble CRTs to the complex VR headsets – a history lesson.

Introduction

Ever since John Logie Baird first telecast the image of a ventriloquist dummy across a dingy one-bedroom apartment in 1920s London, the science of display technology has forever been obsessed with improving the way images and videos are broadcast virtually. Simple cathode ray tubes with electrons pinging mindlessly against a phosphorescent screen have now evolved into a multibillion dollar industry. The humble origins of this field owes its gratitude to the minds of some truly exceptional engineers and scientists who were driven by a need to communicate through the most allusive of our senses: sight. This article pays homage to these men and women, and to the technology they spawned, by trying to trace our fancy 1080p full HD displays back to their roots.

The first CRTs

The first proper piece of display equipment was the Cathode Ray Tube (CRT), a relatively simple piece of equipment despite what every engineering and science student who has ever had the misfortune to have to handle this in a lab will tell you. It operates on the simple principle that electrons, when fired on a screen, produce light, like a microscopic paint ball gun firing pellets into a wall. By adjusting the voltage, and correspondingly